

Unit 7

The Biosphere



"Man's attitude towards nature is today critically important simply because we have now acquired a fateful power to alter and destroy nature. But man is a part of nature and his war against nature is inevitably a war against himself."

– Rachel Carson

Chapter Outline

7.1 Introduction
7.2 Biosphere
7.3 Ecosystem
7.4 Biomes
7.5 Biodiversity
7.6 Endangered Species
7.7 Conservation of biodiversity

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Learning Objectives:

- *Throw light on the importance, vastness and variety that exists in the life sphere.*
- *Describe the distribution of life forms and their adaptations over geographical space.*
- *Sensitise the student on their role in conserving the biosphere.*

7.1 Introduction

The earth was formed 4.6 billion years ago. Geographers are concerned about the earth and its various spheres. These spheres did not exist on the primitive earth as they are today. They evolved over a long period of time after the earth was formed. There was no life on earth for a very long time. Scientists believe that the first life forms on earth came into existence about 3.5 billion years ago. Which marked, 'The birth of the biosphere'.

Since then life has multiplied in numbers and varieties and evolved to the present biosphere that we are part of and which we are gifted with.

In the last 100 years, man has had used, overused and misused the natural resources of the earth. This has disturbed the ecological balance of the earth. The realization about the damage caused to earth by our action came when we began to experience global warming, desertification, increase in diseases and distress and recurrence of severe natural disasters.

It was in 1962 that **Rachel Carson** published the book 'Silent Spring' which inspired an environmental movement that

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